expansion of the organisation had India's internal security establishment deeply concerned.

The PFI had offices in 23 states and Union territories with claims to having around 400,000 members. Its constitution did not mention being a Muslim organisation, though very few people of other religions were members. The leadership was a mix of traditional clerics, university educated professionals and committed ordinary workers. For instance, the West Bengal unit head, Minarul Sheikh, was a 36-year-old with a doctorate in Islamic studies, while the UP entity was led by Waseem Ahmad, a Lucknow-based tailor.

A SOUTHERN PHENOMENON

Earlier headquartered in Kozhikode, Kerala, PFI had shifted its head office to New Delhi, reflecting its desire to be a pan-India organisation. That work is left unfinished. "The PFI didn't exist beyond a couple of states in south India. Nobody knew this organisation in the north," says Prof. Z.M. Khan, secretary general of the Institute of Objective Studies, Delhi. CSDS's Ahmed agrees, saying the PFI remained a southern phenomenon as the culture of organisation-building based on a particular identity is missing among Muslims in the north. Also, there was no inflow of funds from the Gulf like in Kerala.

In 2009, a political outfit named Social Democratic Party of India (SDPI) evolved out of the PFI, with the stated aim of taking up issues particular to Muslims, Dalits and other marginalised communities. The party is the only PFI-affiliated organisation that has not been banned yet. It has members from non-Muslim communities and has done reasonably well in local body elections in Kerala and Karnataka, winning 125 and 225 seats, respectively. It also now has representation in local bodies in West Bengal, Bihar, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Andhra Pradesh.

Since 2013, the SDPI has also been fielding candidates in parliamentary and assembly elections in Karnataka. In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, the party managed about three per cent votes from the Dakshina Kannada seat, a communal hotspot where it has a strong presence. The SDPI is now trying to dissociate itself from PFI. "There is no link between the SDPI and PFI," says party vice-president B.M. Kamble. It's another matter that SDPI members were out on the streets in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka to protest the arrest of PFI leaders. And while it has not been banned, several SDPI members have been arrested in the two rounds of crackdowns probing agencies and police forces carried out on September 22 and 27.

India's investigating agencies were also becoming increasingly concerned about the amount of funds the PFI was collecting. The PFI had claimed that it raises funds through membership drives and donations from well-wishers. All members were expected to contribute at least one per cent of their monthly salary to the organisation or at least Rs 10 per month. If it really had 400,000 members, that itself would be an inflow of at least Rs 40 lakh every month.

LAST HURRAH?
The PFI's political wing members at a Kozhikode rally, Sept. 17



The outfit had not shied away from showcasing its financial might, paying Rs 77 lakh to top lawyer Kapil Sibal in 2019 to fight a legal case. The fund-raising activities are also being investigated by the ED and income tax department. The latter has cancelled the registration granted to PFI and the Rehab India Foundation (RIF). 'The sources of deposits on behalf of PFI with respect to its several bank accounts were not supported by the financial profiles of the account holders and activities of PFI were not being carried out as per their declared objectives,' read the notification banning the outfit.

According to a home ministry dossier, PFI collected funds from West Asian countries through front organisations such as the RIF, Indian Social Forum and Indian Fraternity Forum. The Muslim Relief Network (MRN), a Kerala-based NGO floated by the PFI, was another entity through which it mobilised funds. MRN allegedly has links with the Jeddah-based World Assembly of Muslim Youth (WAMY), a radical Islamic organisation that has been linked to Al Qaeda in the past. What will happen to these funds now, and where they will be

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